

Good support for virtual hardware in use

Virtualization software would emulate the hardware. If it emulates something which the guest operating system you want to install can't recognize or utilise, it becomes useless to try emulating such hardware. In most cases any and all hardware right from the processor and disks to network and display adapters are generally recognizable by most guest operating systems. However, if you're trying to run a Legacy operating system such as Windows 98 while emulating a SATA disk or a dual core processor, you'll land in trouble.

Virtualization software you're trying to run the guest OS on should be able to emulate various types of hardware interfaces and features. This should accommodate the latest technologies as well as older hardware interfaces. Of course, this depends on your usage. So if you're not going to run Windows 98 or the original Linux kernel written by Linus back in early 90's, worry not, most virtualization software can get your job done. Also, some virtualization software come with support for 3D and 2D acceleration. All this will help you get better response from the guest OS.

Networking facilities

Do you want to browse the internet within your guest OS? Or would you try to create two virtual machines and want to run a port scan on the first one from the second one? There are plenty of possibilities with networks. You might want to test how a computer behaves over the network. You might even want to develop a program and test whether it can communicate over the network. You could possibly want to learn the ninja techniques of networking and so on. That sounds good but may not work as well as you expect, if you have poor virtualization software which doesn't give you too many options.

Depending on the software in use, you just may be able to emulate an ethernet connection or wireless network connection. You would be allowed to emulate various networking interface types on different virtual network adapters, try out NAT (use this option, if available, to be able to browse internet on your guest OS), internal adapters, a bridging adapter and so on. Depending on your requirements, go ahead and select the best one. If you're simply trying to be able to browse the net within the virtual machine, most virtualization software can facilitate that.

Guest operating system support

Windows is different from Linux. BSD is not Linux either. Windows XP

